

Framing the Question. Another example of specifying PICO

A WHO panel addressing the management of sepsis confronted the issue of defining the sepsis population. Issues included the following: i) Various definitions of sepsis exist, including a relatively recent new consensus definition. This definition differed from that used in the individual trials, which also differed. ii) The question arose whether the guideline referred only to patients with sepsis at the time of presentation, and if so how define time of presentation (for instance, in the first 24 or 48 hours after presentation). Alternatively, could the population include those not admitted with sepsis, but who developed sepsis while in hospital?

The panel also recognized that the time frame applied to the duration of the intervention (throughout the stay in a critical care setting, throughout hospital stay, or some shorter time frame).

The panel also had to decide the time frame for the outcome. Alternatives included during hospitalization, the first month after hospitalization, or a considerably longer time frame (6 months for instance).